

THE ZERO GARBAGE SYSTEM



BEST MAINTAINED CITY ■ SURAT, GUJARAT

For the moneyed but filthy city of diamonds and silks, the 1994 plague was a wake-up call. Since then, its transformation has been nothing short of miraculous. What differentiates Surat from the rest of the country? Six-lane roads, a rare sense of public awareness when it comes to civic cleanliness, and a municipal body which takes its job seriously. Thanks to S.R. Rao, former municipal commissioner of the city and Gujarat's urban development secretary, the city with a population of 35 lakh has a zero-garbage system on its 28 main roads. Littering on these roads, which are scrubbed clean by 1,600 sweepers every night, entails a fine. Gaurav Path, the road that leads to the airport, might be flanked by 300-odd slums, but its parking spaces, street furniture and service roads make it look like a street in Singapore. Even the slums—95 per cent of them are covered by the city's superb solid waste management system—have basic infrastructure. As Rao puts it, "Where there is a will, there is a way."

by Uday Mahurkar



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